

Negotiating fluidity: How China's "fourth-love" redoes gender within heteronormativity

Sexualities

2026, Vol. 0(0) 1–23

© The Author(s) 2026

Article reuse guidelines:

sagepub.com/journals-permissions

DOI: 10.1177/13634607251413102

journals.sagepub.com/home/sex



Peizhi Huang¹ , Hongcheng Lu¹  and Min Zhu¹

¹School of Journalism and Communication, Tsinghua University, Beijing, China

Abstract

Challenging monolithic understandings of heterosexuality, this paper introduces the “Fourth-love” relationship, an emergent paradigm in contemporary China. Drawing on constructivist grounded theory and in-depth interviews with 22 practitioners, this study analyzes their practice as a process of “negotiating fluidity” within heteronormativity. The findings reveal this negotiation to be a central, ongoing paradox. Practitioners actively deconstruct patriarchal scripts in their intimate lives, primarily through practices of female sexual agency and the performance of male vulnerability. Simultaneously, they consolidate heteronormativity by grappling with anxieties over their public heterosexual identity and navigating the persistence of traditional caretaking roles. This paper conceptualizes “Fourth-love” not as a fixed state, but as a dynamic process of queer heterosexuality. We argue that this study expands the theory by demonstrating how deconstructive aspirations and normative consolidation are not a binary contradiction, but co-exist in a lived negotiation. This offers a non-binary framework for understanding how gender is uniquely contested and “redone” from within heteronormativity, rather than in simple opposition to it, in contemporary China.

Keywords

The fourth-love, queer heterosexuality, redoing gender, heteronormativity, China

Corresponding author:

Peizhi Huang, School of Journalism and Communication, Tsinghua University, 30 Shuangqing Rd, Haidian District, Beijing 100190, China.

Email: mermer1121@outlook.com

Introduction

The Fourth-love relationship (第四爱), an alternative romantic concept, has gained significant attention in mainland China, amassing over 378,000 followers on Baidu Tieba, one of the country's largest online platforms, as of 2024. The "fourth" relationship is in contrast with the three main types of romantic relationships defined by current sexual orientation norms: First-love (traditional heterosexual), Second-love (gay), and Third-love (lesbian). In the initial stages, the concept was associated with specific sexual practices, such as pegging (anal penetration performed by a woman using a strap-on dildo). However, the term has evolved to represent a long-term relational model that signifies more profound changes in emotional dynamics and gender roles (Lin et al., 2023, 2024).

Although a unified definition has not yet been established, the term has gained increasing attention for its redefinition of traditional gender roles within heterosexual dynamics. Notably, the practice shares similarities with established concepts such as heterosexual anal intercourse (HAI) (Fahs and Gonzalez, 2014; McBride and Fortenberry, 2010) or role-reversal relationship (Schuiling, 2005), but it differs in significant ways, especially within the Chinese cultural context. Unlike HAI, the Fourth-love extends beyond a mere sexual preference; its unique gender dynamics influence not only sexual behaviors but also everyday interactions. This complexity places it distinctly between sexual behavior, preference, and sexual orientation. Although a lively debate persists on whether it is a sexual orientation, the majority of practitioners identify as heterosexual, staying connected to a heteronormative framework (Lin et al., 2024). This complexity adds to the ambiguity and mystique surrounding the Fourth-love, placing it distinctly between sexual behavior preference and sexual orientation. To understand this concept comprehensively and its unique implications for gender diversity in the Chinese context, we conducted semi-structured interviews with 22 practitioners. We aimed to delve into how they understand and articulate their sexual behaviors and daily interactions, and how they comprehend, define, and re-do gender within these relationships. Specifically, we analyze this "redoing gender" process as a complex "negotiation of fluidity," where subversive practices and normative anxieties co-exist. Ultimately, we aim to develop a well-defined framework for the "Fourth-love" relationship using grounded theory as our methodology, which can effectively distinguish it from other related concepts.

Literature review

Sex and sexuality in China

The academic understanding of sexuality has evolved to recognize that the categories of "sex" and "sexuality" are not biological universals but are socially constructed (Bauer, 2014; Langdridge and Parchev, 2018; Simula, 2019b). In the Chinese cultural context, the relationship between sex ideology and gender dynamics creates a unique framework for discussing the concept of the Fourth Love.

China's views on sex have evolved significantly due to historical, cultural, and modernization influences, resulting in a complex connection between sex and sexuality (Ho et al., 2018; Yu et al., 2022). In ancient China, the dominant social value framed sex as primarily a procreative duty within marriage, which was closely tied to familial and social order (Mou et al., 2022; Wang, 2004). Interestingly, once a man's procreative duty, especially in marriage, was fulfilled, societal norms did not strongly object to, and even tacitly allowed, male homosexuality (Lau and Ng, 1989; Li et al., 2010; Wei, 2007). Notably, this tolerance, however, was rarely extended to women, who faced considerable restrictions on their sexual behavior, pleasure, and expression (Ho et al., 2018; Yu et al., 2022). In essence, traditional Chinese society treated sex as a social duty of the family unit, with a loose connection to sexual orientation and gender roles.

As Chinese society rapidly modernized, perspectives on sex and sexuality have shifted, with sex increasingly viewed as a source of personal pleasure (Ho et al., 2018). During the family planning period, the state's extensive education on contraception and distribution of birth control products greatly legitimized sexual pleasure, contributing to a so-called "sex revolution" in China (Lin, 2018; Yu et al., 2022). This shift brought the growing acceptance of premarital and extramarital sex, as well as other non-normative sexual behaviors. Meanwhile, the rise of the internet has created online spaces for gathering and discussion among sexual minorities, such as LGBTQ+ and asexual groups (Wang, 2021). Amidst the interplay of culturally conservative traditions and increasingly open sexual culture, numerous unique gender phenomena have emerged within the Chinese context, such as the tragic case of *Tongqi*—women who unwittingly marry gay men due to societal pressures (Chen, 2020; Song et al., 2023; Wang et al., 2020). In this new social context, discussions about sex and sexual orientation became more frequent. At the same time, China's skewed sex ratio has intensified pressure on men to marry, challenging traditional male-dominant gender roles and creating a more complex social environment (Chen and Zhang, 2019). Amidst ongoing gender imbalance and evolving movements, women's social status has objectively improved (Driessen and Sier, 2021). The rising cost for men to enter intimate relationships, reflected in unique phenomena like increasing expectations for bride prices, highlights the changing dynamics of gender in marriage (Chen and Pan, 2023; Jiang and Sánchez-Barricarte, 2012).

The confluence of a liberalizing sexual culture and fluctuating gender dynamics contextualizes the Fourth Love, a novel intimacy that synthesizes non-procreative pleasure with a direct challenge to conventional gender roles. To understand this phenomenon, it is essential to consider the tension between traditional norms and contemporary social changes in China.

Heterosexual anal intercourse (HAI) and queer heterosexuality

To comprehend the "Fourth-love" phenomenon, it is essential to first contextualize it with related concepts, beginning with Heterosexual Anal Intercourse (HAI). Research on Heterosexual Anal Intercourse (HAI), a significant topic within non-normative sexual behaviors, has traditionally focused on male-initiated acts (Fahs and Gonzalez, 2014;

McBride and Fortenberry, 2010). The concept of “pegging,” popularized by Dan Savage in 2001, shifted attention to female-initiated anal penetration of men, sparking new discussions. Further studies illustrate how pegging challenges conventional gender norms, particularly heteronormative frameworks, by promoting a more egalitarian view of sexual pleasure and questioning traditional masculinity (Aguilar, 2017; Branfman and Ekberg Stiritz, 2012; Branfman et al., 2018). While the practice of Fourth-love resembles pegging in that both involve female-led penetrative roles during sexual encounters, Fourth-love offers a deeper critique of societal norms. It challenges not only sexual roles but also broader gender identities and relationships in everyday contexts, more directly confronting traditional gender norms and patriarchal structures. This aligns it with broader movements within queer heterosexuality that aim to redefine straight identity (Lin et al., 2023, 2024). Therefore, we propose understanding the Fourth-love through the lens of queer heterosexuality, viewing it as a distinctive form of queer heterosexuality within the Chinese context.

The framework of queer heterosexuality thus offers a valuable perspective. The term first entered academic terrain with the publication of *Straight with a Twist: Queer Theory and the Subject of Heterosexuality* (Thomas, 2000), where Heasley (2000) defines queer heterosexuals as those whose practices disrupt the heteronormative construction of gender roles and expression, while simultaneously “adorning the queer space and the queerness way of being”.

The concept of queer heterosexuality offers a potential challenge to heteronormativity. The foundational critique of heteronormativity as a patriarchal system is a cornerstone of gender and queer theory (e.g., Butler 1997; Foucault 1978; Rich 1980; Rubin 1984). This critique sparked a long-standing theoretical debate about the possibilities of resistance within heterosexuality. While some scholars remain sceptical about the potential of queer heterosexuality to systematically transform sociocultural relations (Kitzinger and Wilkinson, 1994; Schlichter, 2004), others have long advocated for a more fluid and diverse understanding of straight identity (e.g., De Beauvoir 1974; Irigaray 1985; Seidman 2001), for instance through concepts like androgyny as a powerful means to deconstruct heteronormative standards and achieve gender equality (Bem, 1974; French, 1985; Millett, 1970). This potential is further highlighted by the shift in gender studies from biological determinism towards a rising social constructionist perspective. This theoretical move reinforces the capacity of queer heterosexuality to challenge heteronormativity (Parsons and Bales, 1955; West and Zimmerman, 1987; Ollenburger and Moore, 1992). Contemporary discussions of role-reversal relationships in Western non-academic contexts resemble the “Fourth-love” concept, illustrating a form of queer heterosexuality that showcases the fluid possibilities within contemporary society (MacInnis and Buliga, 2020; Vink et al., 2023). However, academic studies on these relationships are limited due to scarce empirical evidence and often focus on social aspects while neglecting the deeper dynamics of sexual behavior and self-identity. Our research on “Fourth-love” in China aims to address this gap, providing insights that may promote a dialogue between gender practices in China and the West.

Gender in BDSM and the fourth-love

While direct research on Fourth-love is sparse, initial studies offer insights into its associated gender dynamics and psychological traits. For instance, using the Sex-Role Inventory and the Marital Attitude Scale, [Lin et al. \(2023\)](#) found that women in these relationships often adopt more masculine roles while men assume neutral or more feminine identities. However, a key limitation of such research is its tendency to oversimplify “Fourth-love” as a mere reversal of gender roles, thereby ignoring the fluid and continuous nature of heterosexuality ([Seidman, 2001](#)). Consequently, while these studies distinguish “Fourth-love” from the body-mind dissonance of transgender experiences or the recreational nature of pegging, they remain constrained by heteronormative frameworks ([Lin et al., 2024](#)). This approach leaves significant gaps: it fails to conduct a thorough comparison with traditional heterosexual dynamics, neglects practitioners’ self-constructed identities and experiences of sexual pleasure, and does not fully examine how China’s unique cultural context shapes these relationships.

Addressing these limitations requires a more nuanced framework that connects sexual practice to the Chinese social context to analyze how individuals negotiate gender in sexual transgression. The field of BDSM research provides a robust lens for this inquiry, given its theoretical evolution from a pathological view to a social constructionist perspective ([Bauer, 2014](#); [Fennell, 2021](#); [Newmahr, 2010](#); [Weiss, 2011](#); [Wuyts and Morrens, 2022](#)). This shift recognizes BDSM not merely as a sexual behavior but as a valid subculture where participants actively construct a “different economy of bodies and pleasures” within specific social and political contexts ([Simula, 2019a](#); [Fennell, 2021](#)). Importantly, [Simula’s \(2019a\)](#) three-dimensional framework for understanding BDSM serves as the foundation for our analysis of “Fourth-love”. This framework identifies three key dimensions: the sexual (body) dimension, where practitioners redefine pleasure by decoupling it from traditional genital-centric norms; the relational dimension, where negotiated power and emotional intimacy are prioritized over heteronormative scripts; and the social dimension, where these practices exist as a form of critique against conventional gender roles and sexual hierarchies ([Fennell, 2021](#); [Langdridge and Parchev, 2018](#)). By adopting this BDSM-informed approach, we can transcend a simplistic interpretation of “Fourth-love” as a mere sexual preference and instead analyze it as a distinct social and relational phenomenon with deeper significance.

While BDSM is often viewed as a set of behaviors, it is more accurately understood as a social subculture where the negotiation of power, consent, and identity directly engages with gender norms ([Langdridge and Parchev, 2018](#); [Carlström, 2019](#)). This makes BDSM a valuable lens for studying the gender politics within “Fourth-love,” as both practices inherently question gender roles and dynamics.

Moving beyond the binary academic debate of whether BDSM reinforces or subverts gender stereotypes, the empirical work of [Simula and Sumerau \(2019\)](#) offers a more nuanced perspective. Their study of 32 practitioners reveals a coexisting duality in gender negotiation strategies, demonstrating that participants simultaneously deploy two interpretive frameworks to embed social gender structures into their erotic practices. Their research identifies two primary strategies: “downplaying gender”, which actively de-

genders roles to create a “gender-blind” space, and “emphasizing gender”, which consciously appropriates traditional gender discourse and can paradoxically reinforce gender essentialism.

This dual framework provides a crucial analytical tool, allowing us to discern how “Fourth-love” practitioners engage in a wider spectrum of gender practices that include, but are not limited to, simple gender reversal and de-gendering.

In conclusion, Fourth-love represents a unique form of queer heterosexuality born in a unique real Chinese cultural context, challenging existing frameworks for understanding sexuality and gender. Therefore, based on the theoretical framework of BDSM and queer heterosexuality, we conducted a qualitative study using grounded theory to explore how practitioners perceive and construct their sexual identities. Our research addresses two key questions:

Research Question 1. How do “Fourth-love” practitioners experience and conceptualize their self-identities and gendered practices within their intimate relationships?

Research Question 2. In what ways do the gendered practices and identities within “Fourth-love” relationships navigate the norms and scripts of conventional heterosexuality in China?

Method

Research methodology

This research employs the constructivist grounded theory developed by Charmaz in 1995 as the primary research method. Grounded theory is a qualitative approach with the primary purpose of building a theory based on empirical data (Charmaz, 1995; Strauss, 1987) and has been widely studied by researchers since its inception. As a post-development of grounded theory, a theory is viewed as a product of explanatory analysis and artificial construction. Through the explanatory description of the research object’s life situation, emotions, and actions, we can understand how they construct meaning through their behavior, intention, and affection (Charmaz, 2014; Charmaz and Antony, 2011).

Positionality and trustworthiness

The research team’s subjectivity within constructivist methodologies can significantly affect findings. Thus, we conducted ongoing self-reflection on biases during data analysis to enhance the study’s validity and trustworthiness.

All authors, based in China and with Chinese heritage, possess relevant experience in gender research, qualitative analysis, and an appreciation of Chinese culture. The first author has 5 years of experience in the Fourth-love community, while the second and third authors identify as non-binary and heterosexual, respectively. Given the lack of a precise theoretical framework for the Fourth-love, the first author proposed using constructivist grounded theory. The authors conducted in-depth qualitative studies to

ensure rigorous coding and analysis. The heterosexual female author's lack of prior knowledge about the Fourth-love facilitated a more objective interview process, reducing the potential for subjective bias.

Recruitment and participants

This study employed semi-structured, in-depth interviews with 22 participants recruited through two rounds. The initial recruitment occurred on Chinese social media platforms, such as Weibo and Douban, where the Fourth-love community is actively engaged. Due to the group's cautious nature, permission was obtained from three administrators of the Douban forum to post the recruitment notice. The first round yielded mainly female participants, necessitating a second round via snowball sampling. Access to a Fourth-love-only WeChat group of approximately 500 members facilitated the recruitment of male participants.

Due to the lack of contemporary research, participants were not subjected to overtly restrictive criteria such as gender, age, or occupation. According to Article 17 of the *Civil Code of the People's Republic of China* (2020), a natural person who is 18 years or older is considered an adult. Hence, the participants were selected above to ensure ethical and legal compliance. Furthermore, to account for the current unclear definitions of Fourth-love, the researchers employed an inclusion criterion requiring participants to engage in pegging to ensure they possess relatively higher self-cognition, self-awareness, and practicality in what they are positioning. Additionally, we took into account the interviewees' diverse personal traits and statuses during the selection process, aiming to encompass a broader range of profiles within the community while gaining more valuable insights. For instance, our participants included community event organizers, the Fourth-love KOL in Douyin (TikTok), and live chat administrators with over 300 members.

As shown in [Table 1](#), the research team enlisted 15 women and seven men. This outcome also corresponds precisely to the ratio derived through the group observation and recruitment process: the ratio of active females to males in the group is approximately 2:1.

Procedure

Prior to the interview, participants completed a short questionnaire through WeChat chats to confirm their basic information, such as psychological and physiological gender, sexual orientation, experiences with pegging, etc. Due to the study's sensitivity, the research team obtained verbal consent from the participants at the start of the interview by declaring, i.e., that the interview would be presented anonymously in the study. Interviews were conducted in real-time voice chat, each lasting from 27 minutes to 1 hour and 37 minutes, depending on participants' willingness to share. All participants received certain remuneration afterwards.

The procedure and protocol (see [Appendix 2](#)) for conducting semi-structured interviews were guided by a systematic literature review of queer heterosexuality, and the study obtained ethics approval. An experienced Fourth-love participant verified them to

Table 1. Demographics of participants (source: created by authors).

Participants name	Biological	Sex	Gender	Sexual orientation	Gender ideology	Interview time
1	Lian	Male	Cisgender	Heterosexual	Non-binary	38min
2	Nora	Female	Cisgender	Bisexual	Non-binary	51min
3	Riley	Female	Cisgender	Bisexual	Non-binary	47min
4	Aria	Female	Cisgender	Heterosexual	Non-binary	35min
5	Zoey	Female	Cisgender	Pansexual	Non-binary	1h,01min
6	Ivy	Female	Cisgender	Bisexual	Non-binary	1h,18min
7	Levi	Male	Cisgender	Heterosexual	Non-binary	1h,37min
8	Mia	Female	Cisgender	Heterosexual	Non-binary	36min
9	Liu	Male	Cisgender	Heterosexual	Non-binary	35min
10	Emma	Female	Cisgender	Pansexual	Non-binary	1h,01min
11	Owen	Male	Cisgender	Heterosexual	Non-binary	1h,03min
12	Violet	Female	Queer	Pansexual	Non-binary	1h,10min
13	Lucy	Female	Cisgender	Pansexual	Non-binary	1h,02min
14	Alice	Female	Cisgender	Bisexual	Non-binary	34min
15	Zhao	Female	Queer	Pansexual	Non-binary	27min
16	Qian	Female	Queer	Pansexual	Non-binary	45min
17	Jane	Female	Cisgender	Pansexual	Non-binary	36min
18	Yin	Male	Cisgender	Heterosexual	Non-binary	42min
19	Li	Male	Cisgender	Heterosexual	Non-binary	28min
20	Frank	Male	Cisgender	Heterosexual	Non-binary	50min
21	Melo	Female	Queer	Bisexual	Non-binary	37min
22	Tomi	Female	Cisgender	Bisexual	Non-binary	29min

ensure the soundness and applicability of the interview questions. The interview consisted of demographic questions (e.g., age, sexual orientation, gender identity) and conversations encouraging participants to share their perceptions and definitions of the Fourth-love. The research team divided the interview into three sections: defining the Fourth-love, group identity, and sexual experience. We began with questions such as: *How do you understand the Fourth-love relationship? What do you think are the most distinctive features of the Fourth-love?* Additional questions were added based on the responses of the interviewees.

The research team created a supportive environment to encourage participants to self-disclose. The first author established rapport while the other authors moderated discussions and monitored participants' emotional states. In this comfortable setting, participants shared their community perceptions (including biases, self-positioning disputes, and common myths), personal romantic/sexual experiences, and views on gender hegemony. Follow-up questions were added organically based on responses. All interviews were audio-recorded, transcribed verbatim, and anonymized. Researchers documented emergent themes through memo writing during interviews to refine the methodology for subsequent discussions.

Data analysis

This study utilized NVivo (v.12) as the primary analytical tool and implemented Charmaz's (2014) analytical logic in the analysis process by continuously comparing sets of data (Charmaz, 2014; Glaser and Strauss, 1967) in an iterative approach to evolve new concepts and categories until the theoretical model was generalized. No predetermined orientations or findings were presented in the initial coding phase, with 22 sample transcripts being coded verbatim, generating up to 362 relevant codes. In the next stage, focused codings generated holistically with the author's previous expertise, the codes with higher frequency and theoretical value were filtered out or combined into multiple more advanced dimensions. The results were inductively inferred and ultimately formed 19 subcategories.

As the focused coding stage yielded a sufficiently explicit framing route, the authors discussed coding and cross-checked it at each stage, transitioning seamlessly into theoretical coding without adopting the axial coding presented by Strauss and Corbin (1990, 1998). The coding from previous stages remained fragmentary; however, theoretical coding enabled these fragments to be pieced together into a coherent narrative (Charmaz, 2014; Glaser, 1992). Through this process of continually unravelling the relations across categories, three core components of the "Fourth-love" relationship were constructed: *Fluid and Interchangeable Gender Roles*, *The Challenge to Heteronormativity*, and *the overarching concept of "Redoing Gender"*. The first author completed all coding individually and left approximately twenty percent of the interviews ($n = 5$) for recursive coding with the other author to ensure no biases and considered attaining preliminary saturation (Charmaz, 2014). Five focused codings were revamped at this stage, and the initial framework was built following deliberations. Altogether, the three authors dedicated more than 20 hours of joint discussion on several occasions during the process.

After the authors rigorously debated participants' active and passive tendencies regarding the core category of *The Challenge to Heteronormativity*, theoretical sampling was conducted to induce a degree of inference (Charmaz, 2014) and to precisely verify the reliability and saturation of the framework.

Theoretical saturation

In grounded theory, data saturation refers to the point at which conceptual categories yield no new properties (Glaser, 1969; Charmaz, 2006). Although its precise definition remains contested, the process involves comparing categories until new attributes cease to emerge, with verification methods including sample testing, expert assessment and reinterviewing (Aldiabat and Le Navenec, 2018).

Saturation occurs at multiple analytical levels; studies suggest at least nine interviews are needed for "code saturation" and 16 or more for "meaning saturation" (Hennink et al., 2017; Aldiabat and Le Navenec, 2018). Based on these parameters, our interview corpus has achieved meaning saturation. To validate our framework, a three-hour focus group was conducted with five key contributors. Their collaborative engagement enhanced both individual perspectives and the final explanatory framework, which the group endorsed

without offering additional input. Subsequent saturation testing led to minor refinements to the initial coding but revealed no new core dimensions.

Results

Based on the data analysis, nineteen focused codes and seven sub-themes were synthesized into the three core themes of our conceptual framework. As presented in Figure 1, the “Fourth-love” relationship can be interpreted through four components: a Core Component, a Subversive Element, their intersecting Core Principles, and an Overarching Concept. Demographically, nearly all participants were cisgender, and most identified as heterosexual. Their understanding of gender is less related to innate identity and more to the performance of social roles. Inductively, a shared value emerged: participants did not adhere to a singular, fixed perception of gender, often describing their own expressions as fluid or non-binary. During the theoretical coding stage, the subcategories of (a) physical and sensual dynamics, (b) psychological and emotional roles, and (c) social gender

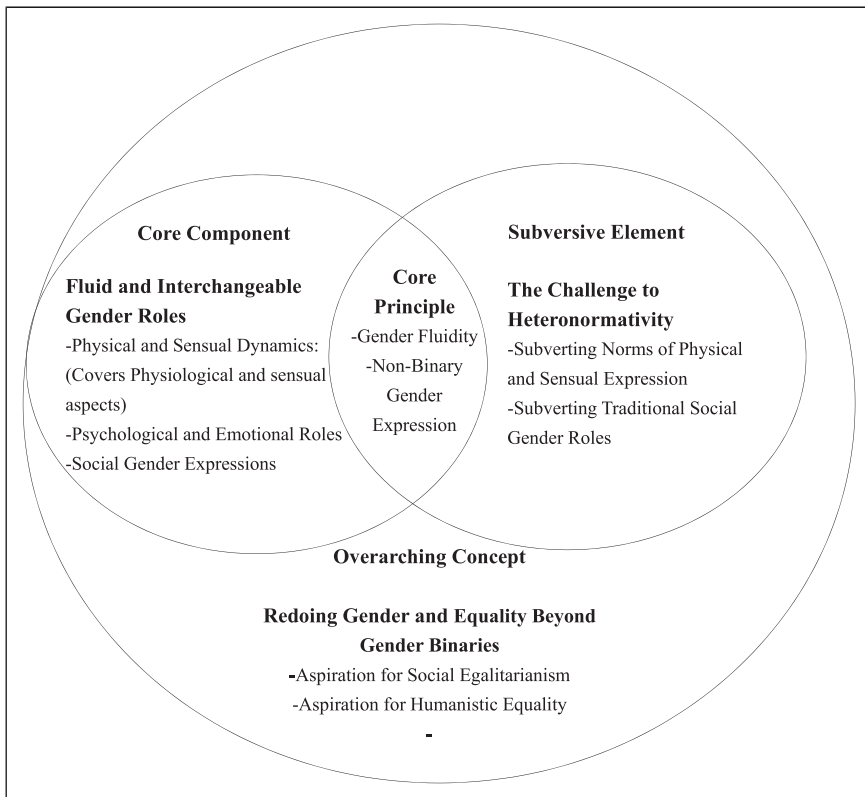


Figure 1. The conceptual framework of the Fourth-love intimate relationship.

expressions were amalgamated into the Core Component: “*Fluid and Interchangeable Gender Roles*”. The second core category, the Subversive Element, was defined as “*The Challenge to Heteronormativity*”, which entails a subversion of the aforementioned gendered dynamics. We merged the physical and psychological aspects, as our analysis indicated they were significantly linked and that their subversion was not gender-specific.

Although the concept of a “challenge” implies a proactive stance, only a portion of participants expressed a clear intention to be proactive. For many, it is a passive form of resistance that arises objectively from their deviation from dominant heteronormative values, a process of overthrowing the old before establishing the new. This aligns with the framework’s Overarching Concept: the process of “*Redoing Gender*”. Nearly all participants expressed a commitment to equality, aiming to move beyond fixed gender roles to pursue a state of “*Equality Beyond Gender Binaries*”.

Remaking the intimacy of heterosexuality

Pegging as a site of gender negotiation. A distinguished aspect of the “Fourth-love” relationship is the practice of pegging, in which a woman engages in anal intercourse with her partner using a strap-on dildo (Savage, 1999). Feminist discourse has debated whether the dildo reinforces patriarchal domination (Minge and Zimmerman, 2009) or challenges structural heteronormativity (Reich, 1992). To move beyond this binary, we analyze pegging as a primary site for the complex negotiation of gender. It is a key practice through which practitioners enact the Core Component of Fluid & Interchangeable Gender Roles, using what can be described as a cyborgian phallus to transfer physiological functions and reshape the social meanings of the body.

For female participants, this act is a clear expression of sexual agency. It allows them to transcend anatomical limitations and adopt a penetrative role, directly subverting normative scripts of female passivity. As Ivy and Jane explain:

The anatomical structure prevents the female from penetrating the male, but sex toys and pegging can achieve the exchange of physiological function. (Ivy, a cisgender bisexual woman)

Society taught them (men) to be the penetrators and the active ones in sex, but in the Fourth-love, they can also be the submissive ones. (Jane, a cisgender queer woman)

From their perspective, these sexual acts liberate individuals from regulatory body functions, allowing them to explore culturally deviant coital positions and obtain erotic gratification outside socially confined behaviors. However, to understand this as a relational dynamic, the male perspective is crucial. For male participants, the experience is framed not as a simple adoption of a ‘feminine’ role, but as a profound act of trust and vulnerability, where the eroticism is intrinsically linked to the transgression of masculine norms.

For me, the physical act is only part of it. The real intensity comes from the vulnerability. As a man, you are conditioned always to be the one in control, to never expose yourself like that. To willingly let her take that role, to be completely open to her... it is the deepest form of trust I can imagine. That vulnerability is where the real intimacy, and honestly, the excitement, comes from for me. (Levi, a cisgender male)

This dynamic illustrates how “Fourth-love” is a space for “Redoing Gender” rather than erasing it. The act is not “degendered”; rather, it is intensely gendered, but in a way that reworks normative expectations. The male performance of vulnerability is a Subversive Element that challenges patriarchal masculinity. Yet, as literature on BDSM practices has shown, these subversive acts can coexist with the reinforcement of other norms (Simula and Sumerau, 2019; Weiss, 2011). For example, the male partner’s ability to embrace vulnerability may be contingent on the female partner providing a “safe space”, a dynamic that can echo traditional female caretaking roles, albeit in a highly unconventional context.

Therefore, this betrayal of orthodox conduct achieves more than just diversified sex acts. Based on our participants’ experiences, this process involves reconfiguring one’s relationship with the body: it establishes the female body as an autonomous agent and, for men, resignifies the anus beyond its typical homoerotic connotations (cf. O’Rourke 2005; Warner 1990). It is in this complex, lived negotiation of female agency, male vulnerability, and the constant interplay between challenging and reinforcing norms that the intimacy of heterosexuality is being remade.

The duality of pleasure: Conquest and care in “Fourth-love” intimacy. While research on pleasure in queer heterosexuality is limited, participants indicated that “Fourth-love” practices serve to reclaim a complex form of sexual pleasure, encompassing reciprocal orgasms, intimacy, and psychological excitement (McClelland, 2014). This pleasure is understood as both physiological (clitoral/prostate stimulation) and psychosocial (orgasm in mind). As a cisgender asexual woman, Zoey said, “*the difference between physiological and psychological pleasure is minor. Both lead to dopamine release and result in feelings of happiness and orgasm.*”

A key site for this negotiation is the phenomenon of dacryphilia, where female participants expressed arousal from their male partner’s tears. This practice reveals a profound duality. On one hand, it functions as a Subversive Element that challenges patriarchal power. The male performance of vulnerability shatters traditional masculine stoicism, and for the female participants, this can be experienced as a form of conquest and agency. As Zoey and Emma described:

Seeing him cry makes me happy because he is crying due to my actions... There is a sense of rebellion against gender stereotypes... There is a sense of conquest. (Zoey, a cisgender pansexual woman)

It is like a challenge, right? Challenged the all-time tradition of men penetrating women. Well, let’s see what happens when I am the Top. (Emma, a cisgender pansexual woman)

However, this subversive pleasure coexists with the reinforcement of other, more traditional gender norms. The moment of male vulnerability is often immediately followed by the female partner adopting a caretaking role, a dynamic that can reproduce normative scripts of female emotional labor. As Ivy stated:

I will give emotional support to my partner. I will feel valuable in this relationship and get excitement and pleasure from this mentality. (Ivy, a cisgender bisexual woman)

This dual experience of pleasure—as both subversive conquest and normative care—is deeply informed by the fact that the majority of our female interlocutors identified as bisexual or pansexual. This is not a mere demographic detail; it is central to understanding their engagement with “Fourth-love”. As research has shown, bisexual and pansexual women often develop a more expansive and critical perspective on heteronormative scripts through their experiences with same-sex desire and relationships (Tarantino and Wesche, 2024). Their sexuality is not oriented around a gender binary, but around a person, which inherently challenges the fixed roles that undergird conventional heterosexuality (Erickson-Schroth, 2014). For these women, “Fourth-love” is not an introduction to queerness, but rather a queer laboratory in which to experiment with a heterosexual dynamic on their own terms. Qian, a cisgender queer woman, articulated this connection with striking clarity:

My attraction is not limited by gender, which means I have seen what intimacy can look like outside of the typical script. Being with women showed me that power and pleasure can be fluid. I bring that expectation into my relationships with men. “Fourth-love” is the only dynamic where a man is willing to explore that fluidity with me, to deconstruct his own role instead of just performing it. (Qian, a cisgender queer woman)

Qian’s statement reveals that the desire for a “Fourth-love” dynamic is often rooted in a pre-existing queer consciousness. It explains why the performance of male vulnerability is so compelling: it is a sign that the male partner is willing to engage in the work of “deconstructing” his masculinity, thereby creating a space that aligns with the more fluid and egalitarian ethics of queer relationships. This context reframes the dynamic of conquest and care not as a simple contradiction, but as the active process of queer women attempting to reshape heterosexuality from within.

The pleasure described is rooted not in conquest but in providing care and feeling valued in a supportive role. Crucially, this analysis is incomplete without the male perspective on this exchange of pleasure and vulnerability. Male participants described this psychosocial pleasure in two interconnected ways: as an act of profound intimacy and as a liberating transgression.

For me, the pleasure is not just physical. It is the emotional release that comes from choosing to be completely vulnerable. To give someone that level of trust is the most intense form of intimacy, and that is where the real orgasm is—in the mind. (Levi, cisgender male)

Psychosocial pleasure is everything. It is about shattering the rigid box of what a “man” is supposed to be. The real excitement comes from that shared transgression—from breaking a major taboo together with someone you trust completely. That is a pleasure far more intense than a physical one. (Frank, cisgender male)

This complex interplay shows that pleasure in “Fourth-love” is not a simple indicator of “gender equality.” Instead, it is a site of intense gender negotiation. The participants recognize that the physical act is less important than the relational context. As Emma elaborated, a change in mindset is what transforms power relations: *“for some, even if you engage in pegging, you still do not obtain gender equality... on the other hand, even if the girl plays the submissive role, as long as the man respects the woman, then gender equality is achieved”*.

For Fourth-love practitioners, the key to resisting hegemony lies not in the simple reversal of a physical act, but in the conscious, mutual construction of a relational space where pleasure, power, and identity can be fluidly renegotiated. This insight, drawn from their lived experiences, provides a powerful real-world illustration of theoretical concepts like “operating within the matrix of power” (Butler 1999, p. 277). It demonstrates that for this community, challenging domination is not an abstract slogan, but a conscious and practical relational strategy.

The politics of pleasure: subverting sexual scripts and identities. A central element of the “Fourth-love” practice is the challenge to heteronormativity, which unfolds through the subversion of normative sexual scripts. For many female participants, this begins with a rejection of penetration-centric sex, which they often associate with pain, guilt, or obligation. While they may not frame this as an explicit political subversion, their pursuit of a more diverse and inclusive sexual repertoire objectively challenges dominant sexual scripts and pleasures.

This subtle challenge from women is mirrored by a more explicit and complex negotiation of identity among the male participants. A significant tension defines their practice: they openly embrace anal eroticism—a pleasure culturally stigmatized and associated with homosexuality (Branfman et al., 2018)—while simultaneously and forcefully policing the boundaries of their own heterosexual identity, a dynamic rooted in the cultural link between sexual acts and masculine identity (Wignall et al., 2020). This was a consistent theme across all our male interviews, articulated with particular clarity by Levi:

Let’s be very clear about one thing: I am heterosexual. I am only attracted to women. I have absolutely no interest in men sexually; in fact, the idea is completely unappealing to me. The pleasure from anal play for me has nothing to do with homosexuality. It has everything to do with the intense trust and intimacy I share with my partner. It is an experience with her, not just a physical act detached from our relationship.” (Levi, cisgender male)

Levi’s testimony is a prime example of the central tension within “Fourth-love”. He engages in a practice that is a subversive element challenging heteronormativity, yet he

simultaneously reinforces the rigidity of sexual identity categories. This demonstrates that “Fourth-love”, for these men, is a conscious choice within a heterosexual framework, not a transitional phase. The ideological work performed by practitioners is to decouple the act from the identity. The community achieves this by reframing anal pleasure not as a signifier of sexual orientation, but as a universal human capacity. As Zoey explained, *“anal eroticism is a right that all men should enjoy as human beings, not just homosexuals, and should not be ashamed of.”*

This dual process—of women expanding the definition of pleasure and men decoupling pleasure from sexual identity—creates a space for a uniquely fluid and diverse sexual practice, as described by Aria:

It might not be like the traditional First-love, where every time is about penetration... We can use our hands or toys... It is more diverse, inclusive, and fluid. We do not need to stick to any rules; we just need to make each other feel good. (Aria, a cisgender heterosexual woman)

However, this dynamic is not a simple progression “towards post-gender beings.” Rather, it is a clear example of “Redoing Gender” in practice. While practitioners reclaim bodily functions and challenge the dichotomy of male dominance, the process is fraught with contradictions. The need for male participants to constantly reassert their heterosexuality reveals the persistent power of normative gender structures. As Riley proclaimed, true “equality necessitates abandoning gender identities,” yet the Fourth-love practice shows how deeply ingrained these identities are, even amidst radical sexual exploration. They are not escaping gender; they are actively and messily renegotiating its terms. It is in this complex, and at times contradictory, negotiation that “Fourth-love” offers an alternative to, rather than a complete overthrow of, conventional heterosexuality.

“Redoing gender” in the social sphere: the interplay of ideals and realities

The practice of “Fourth-love” extends beyond the bedroom into the social sphere, where participants aspire to create desexualized selves informed by queer ideologies. It is here, however, that the complex process of “Redoing Gender”—the constant interplay between challenging and reinforcing norms—becomes most apparent.

Fluidity in expression, aspiration for equality. Participants consciously reject fixed gender roles in their daily lives. For many, this is not just a preference but a necessity. Cisgender women view these relationships as spaces for freedom among like-minded individuals, while for the non-binary participants in our study, the community offers a crucial shelter from social stigmatization. As Zhao, a non-binary pansexual, explained their identity:

Partly I feel like a man and other parts like a woman... But I am biologically a woman and was educated as a girl. (Zhao, a queer female)

This foundational desire for a space free from rigid gender binaries translates into a fluid and contextual gender expression. Participants feel empowered to defy stereotypes, a practice which can achieve a form of power similar to that held by men (Paechter, 2006):

I ride motorcycles, and sometimes he does manicures or dresses in Lolita style... It is all possible. (Jane, a cisgender female)

Crucially, this rejection of stereotypes is not about a simple role-reversal, which participants view as an unhealthy reversion of chauvinism. The stated goal is a more fundamental equality. This sentiment was echoed strongly by the male participants, who saw their embrace of tender characteristics not as a performance, but as a natural part of a relationship built on a different foundation. As Li, a cisgender male, clarified:

It is not about her becoming “the man” and me becoming “the woman.” That is just trading one power imbalance for another. For us, equality means neither of us is automatically assigned a role. We build it from scratch based on who we are, not what society expects us to be. (Li, a cisgender male)

Household labor and the persistence of norms. This aspiration for equality is most rigorously tested in the division of household labor, a critical site for gender construction (West and Zimmerman, 1987). Younger female participants, in particular, tend to reject a gendered division, preferring arrangements based on practical factors, such as income. Emma asserted that “who earns more should contribute more to the family regardless of gender.” This aligns with Goldberg’s (2013) observation that even a specialized division of labor can “redo gender” when it is based on preference rather than a fixed gender identity.

Despite this powerful rhetoric of equality, however, practice often reveals the persistent influence of institutionalized heterosexuality (Jackson, 2006). The most telling evidence of this complex dynamic comes from the male participants. When discussing the nuclear family, they often unconsciously revert to sex-based categorizations, normalizing their role as a provider while still viewing it as compatible with equality (s).

This contradiction was articulated with striking self-awareness by Levi, who admitted that his egalitarian ideals clash with deeply ingrained impulses:

I still have the urge to protect my partner... My desire stems from remnants of heteronormativity. (Levi, a cisgender male)

Levi’s statement is a perfect illustration of what Rich (1980) termed “compulsory heterosexuality”—a system so powerful that it regulates the subjectivity even of those who consciously hold queer perspectives. This tension between the desire to create a new, equal dynamic and the unconscious pull of old norms is the very essence of “Redoing Gender”. It is not a finished state of “degendered equality,” but a continuous and often contradictory interplay of ideals and realities.

Discussion: The aspiration for Equality Beyond Gender Binaries

For our interlocutors, gender is deeply ingrained in the fabric of their identities, intimate relationships, and social lives. They perceive a ubiquitous gender perspective as the touchstone that undergirds heteronormativity, and therefore believe that eliminating the gendered world must be tackled by dismantling the gender binary. This aligns with what Lorber (2000) identified as the epistemology of “gender feminists,” for whom the sources of structural inequality lie in socially constructed meanings attributed to biological difference. While a systematic overhaul of the social structure is beyond their individual capabilities, our interlocutors endeavor to dismantle gender’s biased implications within their intimate relationships. This resonates with Smith’s notion (1990) that individuals need to remove gender from the relations of ruling. In the words of Violet (a queer female), this means “*to treat your partner as a human being and abandon all gender frameworks.*”

Following a comprehensive analysis of their relationship dynamics, the present discussion elucidates what distinguishes the “Fourth-love” relationship from conventional heterosexuality. During our interviews, participants consistently highlighted pegging as the symbolic feature that defines the community’s boundary. As the cisgender bisexual woman Tomi noted, “*pegging is the only consensual agreement among the community.*” However, its significance is not merely practical, but ideological; it enables new members to realize the potential of liberating themselves from heteronormative constraints. The male participant Liu pointed out that some members have never experienced pegging, but this does not preclude them from belonging, because “*it is how the underlying ideologies of pegging can reshape their concepts and identities that matters the most.*” Ivy further elaborated on this strategy:

We are well-known for pegging, but it is just a feature and does not represent the community. It entices people to click on the website to scroll to the bottom and understand that features such as pegging and woman-on-top positions are representations of our pursuit of a more equalized relationship. (Ivy, a cisgender female)

The ultimate goal is not the act itself but the aspiration for *Equality Beyond Gender Binaries*. Given that both “Fourth-love” and “First-love” are rooted in heterosexuality, the demarcation can seem to blur. Drawing on post-structuralist insights, interlocutors argued that definitions are not fixed. They see the “Fourth-love” relationship as “a more nuanced classification derived from heterosexuality” that holds the potential to converge with traditional “First-love” in the future, as its values mature and intersect with the latter.

Concluding remarks

This study has investigated the features of the Chinese “Fourth-love” community and how practitioners conceptualize their relationships. Building upon existing literature, our findings show that “Fourth-love” celebrates a queerness that actively reworks the heteronormative construction of gender roles and expression. More importantly, this paper expands the concept of “queer heterosexuality” by presenting a non-binary model grounded

in the distinct context of contemporary China. We have demonstrated that “Fourth-love” is not a simple binary of subversion or reinforcement. Rather, its practitioners are engaged in a constant, messy process where they simultaneously deconstruct patriarchal scripts (through practices of female sexual agency and the performance of male vulnerability) and consolidate heteronormativity (through navigating public identities and the persistence of traditional caretaking roles). This finding challenges us to see queer heterosexuality less as a fixed state and more as an ongoing, contradictory process of “redoing gender” from within.

Practically, this paper challenges the widely accepted definition of “Fourth-love” as simply a female-led relationship or the act of pegging (House of Fourth-love, 2021). As the first empirical study based on in-depth interviews with practitioners, we reveal that they neither identify as transgender nor adore a complete role-reversal. Building on the quantitative study by Chen (2012), we demonstrate that their relationship is deeply rooted in a non-binary gender ideology, where pegging is a means to declare their aspiration for equality.

This pioneering study has certain limitations. Methodologically, our recruitment of participants with post-secondary education, while ethically considerate, may have limited the diversity of our sample. Theoretically, as our purpose was to map the features of this emerging identity, future research could explore the historical and structural factors that gave rise to this pursuit of *Equality Beyond Gender Binaries*, particularly its relationship with contemporary feminist thought.

Gender is constantly perpetuated in our world. The significance of the “Fourth-love” community lies in making the process of “Redoing Gender” visible. When a woman helps her boyfriend with his Lolita-style makeup, it is a small revolution in their intimate relationship; when they proudly share photos on social media, it contributes to a broader social transformation. By providing a space for these small, everyday acts of resistance and interplay with norms, the “Fourth-love” community offers a powerful glimpse into the ongoing, and often contradictory, process of challenging a patriarchal world.

Acknowledgment

The research team appreciates Ms Xiaoshan Yuan for the data collection phase.

Declaration of conflicting interests

All authors declare that they have no affiliations with or involvement in any organization or entity with any financial interest or non-financial interest in the subject matter or materials discussed in this manuscript.

Funding

The authors received no financial support for the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article.

Ethical considerations

This study is approved by the Institutional Review Board of the School of Journalism and Communication, Tsinghua University.

ORCID iDs

Peizhi Huang  <https://orcid.org/0009-0004-9154-0092>

Hongcheng Lu  <https://orcid.org/0009-0006-5757-0946>

Data Availability Statement

The data in this study are primary, and informed consent was obtained from the interviewees before the information was collected. All the interview files can be verified by uploading them to a shared cloud drive.

Supplemental material

Supplemental material for this article is available online.

References

- Aguilar J (2017) Pegging and the heterosexualization of anal sex: an analysis of savage love advice. *Queer Studies in Media & Popular Culture* 2(3): 275–292.
- Aldiabat K and Le Navenec C-L (2018) Data saturation: The mysterious step in grounded theory method. *The Qualitative Report* 23(1): 245–261.
- Baidu T (2024) 第四爱吧 [The forum of the Fourth-love relationship]. *Baidu Tieba*. [online] 24 September. Available at: <https://tieba.baidu.com/p/8673309773> (accessed 17 September 2025).
- Bauer R (2014) *Queer BDSM Intimacies: Critical Consent and Pushing Boundaries*. Springer.
- Bem SL (1974) The measurement of psychological androgyny. *Journal of Consulting and Clinical Psychology* 42(2): 155–162.
- Branfman J and Ekberg Stiritz S (2012) Teaching men’s anal pleasure: challenging gender norms with “prostage” education. *American Journal of Sexuality Education* 7(4): 404–428.
- Branfman J, Stiritz S and Anderson E (2018) Relaxing the straight male anus: decreasing homophobia around anal eroticism. *Sexualities* 21(1–2): 109–127.
- Butler JP (1997) *The Psychic Life of Power: Theories in Subjection*. Stanford University Press.
- Butler JP (1999) *Gender Trouble: Feminism and the Subversion of Identity*. Routledge.
- Carlström C (2019) BDSM, becoming and the flows of desire. *Culture, Health and Sexuality* 21(4): 404–415.
- Charmaz K (1995) Grounded theory. In: Smith JA, Harré R and Langenhove LK (eds) *Rethinking Methods in Psychology*. Sage Publications, 27–49.
- Charmaz K (2006) *Constructing Grounded Theory: A Practical Guide Through Qualitative Analysis*. London: SAGE.
- Charmaz K (2014) *Constructing Grounded Theory*. Sage Publications.
- Charmaz K and Antony B (2011) Grounded theory and credibility. In: Silverman DE (ed) *Qualitative Research: Issues of Theory, Method and Practice*. Sage Publications, 291–309.
- Chen Y (2012) 从“女攻男受”到“第四爱”——试论青少年的性别多元与平等之实践进程 [From female domination and male submission to the Fourth-love: a practical process of sexual/gender diversity and equality among adolescents]. Paper presented at the Gender diversity: journal of theoretical and practical study, Beijing, China, 1 May.
- Chen J (2020) The paradox of gender reversal: dance hosts and the pursuit of gender ideals in contemporary China. *The China Quarterly* 243: 737–756.
- Chen J and Pan W (2023) Bride price and gender role in rural China. *Heliyon* 9(1): e12789.

- Chen R and Zhang L (2019) Imbalance in China's sex ratio at birth: a review. *Journal of Economic Surveys* 33(3): 1050–1069.
- de Beauvoir S (1974) *The Second Sex*. Vintage Books.
- Driessen M and Sier W (2021) Rescuing Masculinity: Giving Gender in the Wake of China's Marriage Squeeze. *Modern China* 47(3): 266–289.
- Erickson-Schroth L (ed) (2014) *Trans Bodies, Trans Selves: A Resource for the Transgender Community*. Oxford University Press.
- Fahs B and Gonzalez J (2014) The front lines of the “back door”: navigating (dis)engagement, coercion, and pleasure in women's anal sex experiences. *Feminism & Psychology* 24(4): 500–520.
- Fennell J (2021) It's complicated: sex and the BDSM subculture. *Sexualities* 24(5–6): 784–802.
- Foucault M (1978) *The History of Sexuality, Vol. 1: An Introduction*. (R. Hurley, Trans.). Pantheon Books. (Original work published 1976).
- French M (1985) *Beyond Power: On Women, Men and Morals*. Ballantine Books.
- Glaser BG (1969) The constant comparative method of qualitative analysis. In: McCall GJ and Simmons JL (eds). *Issues in Participant Observation*. Reading, MA: Addison-Wesley, 216–228.
- Glaser BG (1992) *Basics of Grounded Theory Analysis: Emergence vs Forcing*. Sociology Press.
- Glaser BG and Strauss AL (1967) *The Discovery of Grounded Theory: Strategies for Qualitative Research*. Aldine Transaction.
- Goldberg AE (2013) ‘Doing’ and ‘undoing’ gender: the meaning and division of housework in same-sex couples. *Journal of Family Theory & Review* 5(2): 85–104.
- Heasley R (2000) Crossing the borders of gendered sexuality: queer masculinities of straight men. In: Thomas C (ed) *Straight with a Twist: Queer Theory and the Subject of Heterosexuality*. University of Illinois Press, 109–129.
- Hennink MM, Kaiser BN and Marconi VC (2017) Code Saturation versus Meaning Saturation: How many Interviews are enough? *Qualitative Health Research* 27(4): 591–608.
- Ho PSY, Jackson S, Cao S, et al. (2018) Sex with Chinese characteristics: sexuality research in/on 21st-century China. *The Journal of Sex Research* 55(4–5): 486–521.
- House of Fourth-love (2021) 如何确定自己是第四爱? [How to be sure you are a Fourth-love]. *House of Fourth-love*, [online] 21 April. Available at: <https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/Uyq9pbU5FPcr3F4Utc1WQ> (accessed 27 March 2025).
- Irigaray L (1985) *This Sex which is Not One* (C. Porter with C. Burke, Trans.). Cornell University Press. (Original work published 1977).
- Jackson S (2006) Interchanges: gender, sexuality and heterosexuality: the complexity (and limits) of heteronormativity. *Feminist Theory* 7(1): 105–121.
- Jiang Q and Sánchez-Barricarte JJ (2012) Bride price in China: the obstacle to ‘bare branches’ seeking marriage. *The History of the Family* 17(1): 2–15.
- Kitzinger C and Wilkinson S (1994) Virgins and queers: rehabilitating heterosexuality? *Gender & Society* 8(3): 444–462.
- Langdridge D and Parchev O (2018) Transgression and (sexual) citizenship: the political struggle for self-determination within BDSM communities. *Citizenship Studies* 22(7): 667–684.
- Lau MP and Ng ML (1989) Homosexuality in Chinese culture. *Culture, Medicine and Psychiatry* 13(4): 465–488.
- Li H, Holroyd E and Lau JTF (2010) Negotiating homosexual identities: the experiences of men who have sex with men in Guangzhou. *Culture, Health and Sexuality* 12(4): 401–414.
- Lin Z (2018) Individualizing the sexual revolution in China: staging, enjoying, and experiencing sexuality. *Asian Journal of Women's Studies* 24(4): 446–462.

- Lin H, Zhou W, Ma Y, et al. (2023) Sexual minorities within heterosexuality: psychosocial characteristics of and attitudes toward the “fourth love” in China. *International Journal of Sexual Health: Official Journal of the World Association for Sexual Health* 35(1): 181–192.
- Lin H, Wang Y, Wang H, et al. (2024) Women’s revenge in sexual behavior? An interpretation about “the fourth love” in Chinese youth culture from the perspective of gender performativity. *International Journal of Sexual Health: Official Journal of the World Association for Sexual Health* 36(3): 257–272.
- Lorber J (2000) Using gender to undo gender: a feminist degendering movement. *Feminist Theory* 1(1): 79–95.
- MacInnis CC and Buliga E (2020) “Don’t get above yourself”: heterosexual cross-class couples are viewed less favorably. *Psychology of Women Quarterly* 44(1): 50–66.
- McBride KR and Fortenberry JD (2010) Heterosexual anal sexuality and anal sex behaviors: a review. *The Journal of Sex Research* 47(2–3): 123–136.
- McClelland SI (2014) “What do you mean when you say that you are sexually satisfied?” A mixed methods study. *Feminism & Psychology* 24(1): 74–96.
- Millett K (1970) *Sexual Politics*. Doubleday.
- Minge J and Zimmerman AL (2009) Power, pleasure, and play: screwing the dildo and rescripting sexual violence. *Qualitative Inquiry* 15(2): 329–349.
- Mou Y, Cui Y, Wang J, et al. (2022) Perceiving sexual harassment and #metoo social media campaign among Chinese female college students. *Journal of Gender Studies* 31(2): 178–192.
- Newmahr S (2010) Rethinking kink: sadomasochism as serious leisure. *Qualitative Sociology* 33(3): 313–331.
- Ollenburger JC and Moore HA (1992) *A Sociology of Women: The Intersection of Patriarchy, Capitalism, and Colonization*. Prentice Hall.
- O’Rourke M (2005) On the eve of a queer-straight future: notes toward an antinormative heterosexual. *Feminism & Psychology* 15(1): 111–116.
- Paechter C (2006) Masculine femininities/feminine masculinities: power, identities and gender. *Gender and Education* 18(3): 253–263.
- Parsons T and Bales RF (1955) *Family, Socialization and Interaction Process*. Free Press.
- Reich JL (1992) Genderfuck: the law of the dildo. *Discourse* 15(1): 112–127.
- Rich A (1980) Compulsory heterosexuality and lesbian existence. *Signs: Journal of Women in Culture and Society* 5(4): 631–660.
- Rubin GS (1984) Thinking sex: notes for a radical theory of the politics of sexuality. In: Vance CS (ed) *Pleasure and Danger: Exploring Female Sexuality*. Routledge & Kegan Paul, 267–319.
- Savage D (1999). *Savage Love*. Dutton books.
- Schlichter A (2004) Queer at last? Straight intellectuals and the desire for transgression. *GLQ: A Journal of Lesbian and Gay Studies* 10(4): 543–564.
- Schuilin GA (2005) On sexual behavior and sex-role reversal. *Journal of Psychosomatic Obstetrics and Gynaecology* 26(3): 217–223.
- Seidman S (2001) From identity to queer politics: shifts in the social logic of normative heterosexuality in contemporary America. *Social Thought & Research* 24(1–2): 1–12.
- Simula BL (2019a) A ‘different economy of bodies and pleasures’: Differentiating and evaluating sex and sexual BDSM experiences. *Journal of Homosexuality* 66(2): 209–237.
- Simula BL (2019b) Pleasure, power, and pain: a review of the literature on the experiences of BDSM participants. *Sociology Compass* 13(3): e12668.
- Simula BL and Sumerau JE (2019) The use of gender in the interpretation of BDSM. *Sexualities* 22(3): 452–477.

- Song C, Xie H, Zhou Y, et al. (2023) Sex life and sexuality among tongqi: doing gender and heterosexuality. *Culture, Health and Sexuality* 25(2): 256–269.
- Strauss A (1987) *Qualitative Analysis for Social Scientists*. Cambridge University Press.
- Strauss A and Corbin J (1990) *Basics of Qualitative Research: Grounded Theory Procedures and Techniques*. Sage Publications.
- Strauss A and Corbin J (1998) *Basics of Qualitative Research: Techniques and Procedures for Developing Grounded Theory*. 2nd edition. Sage Publications.
- Tarantino M and Wesche R (2024) Queering cisgender LGB+ women's sexual health scripts. *The Journal of Sex Research* 61(4): 487–499.
- Thomas C (ed) (2000) *Straight with a Twist: Queer Theory and the Subject of Heterosexuality*. University of Illinois Press.
- Vink M, Derks B, Ellemers N, et al. (2023) Penalized for challenging traditional gender roles: why heterosexual relationships in which women wear the pants may be more precarious. *Sex Roles* 88(3–4): 130–154.
- Wang F (2004) Confucian thinking in traditional moral education: key ideas and fundamental features. *Journal of Moral Education* 33(4): 429–447.
- Wang YS (2021) Unfinished revolution: an overview of three decades of LGBT activism in China. *Made in China Journal* 6(1): 90–95.
- Wang Y, Wilson A, Chen R, et al. (2020) Behind the rainbow, “Tongqi” wives of men who have sex with men in China: a systematic review. *Frontiers in Psychology* 10: 2929.
- Warner M (1990) Homo-narcissism; or, heterosexuality. In: Boone J and Cadden M (eds) *Engendering Men: The Question of Male Feminist Criticism*. Routledge, 188–204.
- Wei W (2007) ‘Wandering men’ no longer wander around: the production and transformation of local homosexual identities in contemporary Chengdu, China. *Inter-Asia Cultural Studies* 8(4): 572–588.
- Weiss MD (2011) *Techniques of Pleasure: BDSM and the Circuits of Sexuality*. Duke University Press.
- West C and Zimmerman DH (1987) Doing gender. *Gender & Society* 1(2): 125–151.
- Wignall L, Scoats R, Anderson E, et al. (2020) A qualitative study of heterosexual men's attitudes toward and practices of receiving anal stimulation. *Culture, Health and Sexuality* 22(6): 675–689.
- Wuyts E and Morrens M (2022) The biology of BDSM: a systematic review. *The Journal of Sexual Medicine* 19(1): 144–157.
- Yu J, Luo W and Xie Y (2022) Sexuality in China: a review and new findings. *Chinese Journal of Sociology* 8(3): 293–329.

Peizhi Huang is a Postdoctoral Fellow in the School of Journalism and Communication at Tsinghua University; her research interests encompass gender studies, cultural studies, and sexuality studies, with a particular focus on gender identity, sexual roles and their cognitive processes, and contemporary Chinese popular culture. She was awarded the best paper by the Association for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication (AEJMC) for her contributions to gender studies research.

Hongcheng Lu is a PhD student in the School of Journalism and Communication at Tsinghua University, specializing in gender studies, digital culture, and media economics. His research examines how gender identities and representations are shaped and reshaped in digital spaces. His work has been presented at multiple international conferences, such

as the International Communication Association (ICA), contributing to ongoing discussions on gender representation in the digital era.

Min Zhu is a PhD candidate at the School of Journalism and Communication at Tsinghua University. Her research interests encompass environmental studies, cultural studies, and sexuality studies, with a particular emphasis on gender identity. Her work has been presented at conferences such as the International Association for Media and Communication Research (IAMCR) and the Association for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication (AEJMC).